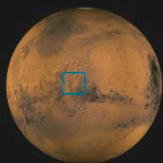


MERIDIANI PLANUM

Endurance Crater



TYPE Bowl crater

AGE Under 4 billion years

DIAMETER 420 ft (130 m)

This small and inconspicuous crater has been explored and investigated to a greater extent than almost any other crater on Mars. In early 2004, it did not even have a name, but by the end of that year, its rim, slopes, and floor had all been imaged and examined by the

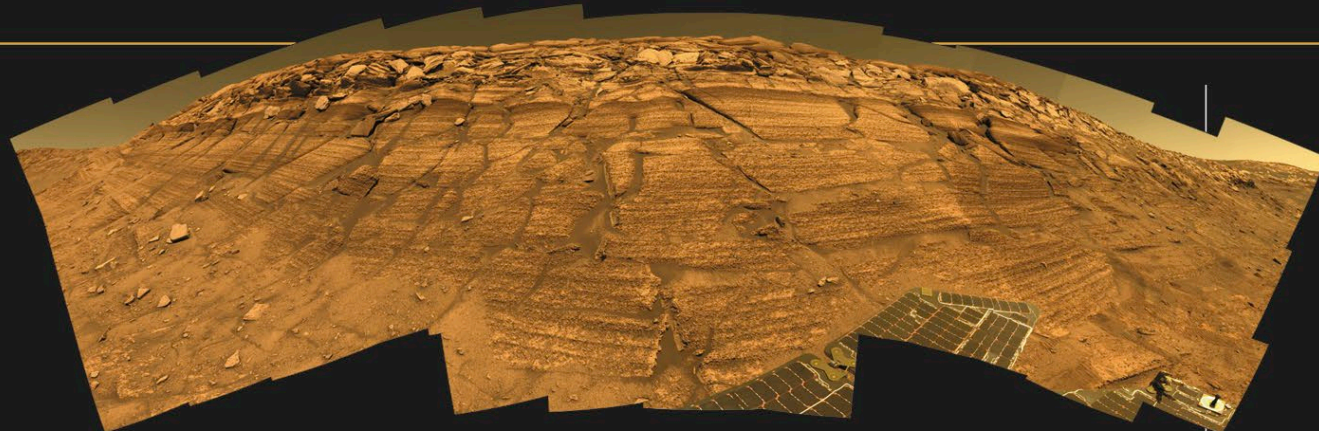


robotic rover Opportunity. The small craft just happened to land within roving distance of this football-field-sized crater when it made its scheduled landing in the Meridiani Planum in Mars's northern hemisphere.

Endurance, named after the ship that carried Irish-born British explorer Ernest Shackleton to the

SAND DUNES

The center of the crater floor is covered by small sand dunes. The reddish dust has formed flowing tendrils, which are a few inches to a yard or so deep.



Antarctic, is an almost circular crater bounded by a rim of rugged cliffs. Its inner walls slope down to the crater floor, 66–100 ft (20–30 m) below. Layers of bedrock line the crater, some of which are exposed; loose material and sand dunes cover the rest of the floor.

Opportunity spent approximately 6 months exploring Endurance. The rover started by traveling around the southern third of the crater's rim; here, it crossed a region named Karatepe and traveled along the edge of Burns Cliff. It then retraced its route to enter the crater on its southwestern limb.

BURNS CLIFF

This portion of the crater's southern inner wall is called Burns Cliff. Forty-six Opportunity images taken in November 2004 combine to make this 180° view. The wide-angle camera makes rock walls bulge unrealistically toward the viewer.

Opportunity made its way down the inner slope, examining rocks and soil along its route. It headed toward the crater's center but got less than halfway before doubling back; any farther and it might have gotten stuck in the sandy terrain. It then exited the crater to

DRAMATIC PANORAMA

This approximately true-color view across Endurance Crater was taken by Opportunity's panoramic camera as the rover perched on the western rim. A dune field lies in the center of the crater.